Chenjun Yu (she/her)

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Areas of Specialization

Postsecondary policy and economics of education · Community colleges and workforce development · Financial aid and transfer policy · Quantitative and mixed methods · Causal inference methods · State administrative data and labor market linkage

Education

May 2027 (exp.) **Ph.D.**, Public Policy in Postsecondary Education, University of Michigan
Dissertation: *Working and Learning in Hard Times: How Employment Downturns Shape Community College Students' School and Job Trajectories*
Committee: Brian McCall (chair), Walt Ecton, Katherine Michelmore, Stacey Brockman

June 2022 **M.A.**, Education Economics & Management, Tsinghua University
Thesis: *Family Background, Vocational Education and Economic Returns*. Advisor: Fengliang Li

June 2019 **B.A.**, Japanese Language & Literature, Tsinghua University

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

2026–27 **Rackham Predoctoral Fellowship**, University of Michigan ($44,000)
∼85 awarded from ∼240 university-wide nominees

2026 **Spencer Scholarship**, APPAM ($1,500)

2026 **Researchers of Color Mentored Travel Award**, SREE ($1,500)

2025 **Postsecondary CTE Research Fellowship**, ECMC Foundation–Old Dominion University ($2,500)
National cohort of 9

2025 **Rackham Graduate Research Grant**, University of Michigan ($1,500)

2024–26 **CSHPE Summer Support Grants**, University of Michigan ($4,200 total)

2024 **ISR–Rackham Summer Training Award**, University of Michigan ($3,000)

2023–26 **Rackham Conference Travel Grants**, University of Michigan ($900 × 4)

2022–23 **Karl C.K. Ma Endowed Fellowship**, University of Michigan ($36,000)

2022 **Outstanding Contribution Award to International Student Affairs**, Tsinghua University

2019–21 **Comprehensive Excellence Scholarship**, Tsinghua University (×3; top 20%)

Advanced Training

2026 Preparing Future Faculty Program, University of Michigan (selected)

2025 Arnold Ventures Innovation Day, APPAM and AEFP (selected)

2025 IES CTE Research Network 2.0 Summer Training Institute (selected)

2024 ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods and ICPSR–MIDAS Social Data Science Summer Academy (full scholarship)

Peer-Reviewed Publications

Li, F., & **Yu, C.** (2022). A study on adjusting the national financial aid amount for master's students: Three estimating approaches. *Journal of Northwestern Polytechnical University (Social Sciences)*. [in Chinese] [Link]
Constructs a cost-of-living index for master's students across China, finding that the National Stipend covers roughly 60% of basic costs and shows substantial geographical variation.

Manuscripts Under Review

Yu, C., Bahr, P. R., Columbus, R., Kreth, Q., & May-Trifiletti, J. Who counts? Identifying career and technical education students at community colleges using state administrative data. Under Review, *Community College Review*.

Manuscripts In Preparation

Yu, C. Working and learning in hard times: How employment downturns shape community college students' enrollment and labor market trajectories. *Draft available upon request*. ⋆ **Job market paper** (Presented: SREE 2026; SFARN 2026)

Uses difference-in-differences and shift-share instrumental variable designs applied to longitudinal state administrative records linked to unemployment insurance wage data to estimate how local employment downturns reshape community college students' enrollment decisions, program choices, and labor market trajectories, with implications for counter-cyclical state policy design and campus-level student support.

Yu, C. Working while enrolled in college: A systematic review of the evidence, 2005–2025. *Draft available upon request*.

Yu, C., Trigger, J. M., Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. Effects of financial aid on student academic and labor market outcomes: The case of Tennessee HOPE. *Draft available upon request*.

Trigger, J. M., **Yu, C.**, Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. Financial aid administrators' perspectives on students' experiences with financial aid. *Draft available upon request*.

Policy Reports & Technical Research

Yu, C., Trigger, J. M., Wang, M., Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. (2026). *White Paper 5: Effect of HOPE renewal on labor market outcomes*. Tennessee Higher Education Commission & CSHPE, University of Michigan. *Under Agency Review*.

Yu, C., Trigger, J. M., Wang, M., Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. (2026). *White Paper 3: Effect of HOPE receipt on labor market outcomes*. Tennessee Higher Education Commission & CSHPE, University of Michigan. *Under Agency Review*.

Trigger, J. M., **Yu, C.**, Skiles, J., McCall, B. P., & DesJardins, S. L. (2026). The effect of receiving Tennessee HOPE on labor market outcomes, 2010–2023. In *Tennessee Education Lottery Scholarship Program 2025 Annual Report* (pp. 38–41). [Link]

Bahr, P. R., **Yu, C.**, Columbus, R., Kreth, Q., & May-Trifiletti, J. (forthcoming). *Who participates in stackable credential pathways? Evidence from Ohio community colleges*. CSHPE, University of Michigan.

Kreth, Q., Bahr, P. R., Columbus, R., **Yu, C.**, & May-Trifiletti, J. (forthcoming). *Work and industry change among students in stackable credential pathways*. CSHPE, University of Michigan.

May-Trifiletti, J., Bahr, P. R., Columbus, R., **Yu, C.**, & Daugherty, L. (2024). *Do low-income students stack high-value credentials?* (Working Paper 24-1). CSHPE, University of Michigan. [Link]

Book Chapters

Yu, C. (2024). Overview: Introduction and conceptual framework. In F. Li (Ed.), *Current situation, problems and countermeasures of adult learning and education*. Zhongguo Shehui Chubanshe. [in Chinese]

Presentations

Invited

Estimating the effect of the Tennessee HOPE Scholarship on academic and labor market outcomes. *Tennessee Higher Education Commission Summer 2026 Commission Meeting*, Clarksville, TN, July 2026. (Co-presented; led presentation of quantitative findings.)

Conference

2026 Working and learning in hard times: How economic downturns shaped community college students' trajectories. *APPAM*, Boston, MA. (scheduled)

2026 Who Counts? Implications of competing definitions of Career and Technical Education students for research findings. *APPAM*, Boston, MA. (scheduled)

2026 Working through college: Consequences, inequity, and policy implications from a systematic review. *ASHE Council on Public Policy in Higher Education (CPPHE) Pre-Conference*, San Juan, PR. (scheduled)

2026 Working and learning in hard times: How employment downturns shape community college students' trajectories. *SREE*, Baltimore, MD.

2026 Working and learning in hard times: How employment downturns shape community college students' school and job trajectories. *SFARN*, Louisville, KY.

2025 Effect of financial aid on labor market outcomes: The case of Tennessee HOPE. *APPAM*, Seattle, WA.

2025 Financial aid administrators' perspectives on students' experiences with financial aid. *ASHE*, Denver, CO.

2025 Work through recession? Unpacking students' working and borrowing behaviors during economic shocks. *CSCC*, Detroit, MI.

2025 Estimating the labor market outcomes of state merit-aid scholarships. *AEFP*, Washington, DC.

2025 Tracking the gains of higher education: A review of gainful employment policy. *CIES*, Chicago, IL.

2024 Working students during recession: An instrumental variables approach. *AEFP*, Baltimore, MD.

2021 Dispelling misconceptions: Did vocational colleges reinforce social stratification in China? *AERA*, virtual.

2020 How to break the isolation of writing: A peer writing advising program in China. *NACADA*, virtual.

Research Positions

2022– **Graduate Student Research Assistant**, University of Michigan

- Lead quantitative analyst, IES-funded evaluation of Tennessee state merit aid (PIs: McCall, DesJardins, Klafehn); RD and IV designs on statewide longitudinal records linked to UI wage data.
- Co-led qualitative arm: designed protocols, conducted interviews with financial aid administrators across Tennessee institutions.
- Analyzed stackable credential pathways and wage outcomes for 30,000+ Ohio community college students, using longitudinal enrollment and UI wage data (PI: Bahr).

2025–26 **Research Assistant**, Detroit Partnership for Education Equity and Research, Wayne State University

- Built an original statewide dataset of Maryland program-level articulation agreements from hundreds of unstandardized documents via AI-assisted extraction; analyzed credit applicability and excess credits among vertical transfer students (PIs: Brockman, Lin).
- Evaluated open educational resources policies across five Michigan community colleges using difference-in-differences designs.

2018–22 **Research Assistant**, Tsinghua University

- Led a research team producing a national policy report on adult learning and education; policy analysis in partnership with the National Student Financial Aid Center (PI: Li).

Teaching and Mentoring

2025–26 **Research Mentor**, University of Michigan

- Mentor two master's students on a faculty-led research team in question formulation, analytic strategy, and interpretation.

2026 **Guest Lecturer**, University of West Georgia

- *ECON 1101, Economics of Financial Literacy*: lecture on college affordability, financial aid, and degree persistence.

2020–21 **Instructional Assistant**, Tsinghua University

- *Academic Writing and Critical Thinking* (undergraduate, ∼15 students): led discussion sections; evaluated 30+ essays per term.
- *College Student Psychological Development* (undergraduate, 3 semesters, ∼80 students/term): small-group tutoring; assessment of applied theory projects.

Courses prepared to teach: Research design for education policy · Applied causal inference · Introduction to higher education policy · Community college policy · Quantitative and mixed methods

Professional Experience

2019–22 **Project Manager**, Academic Support Program, Tsinghua University

- Directed a program serving 1,500+ advising sessions annually; supervised 20 graduate advisors and 3 undergraduate assistants; managed budget, training materials, and quality assurance.
- Redesigned delivery model during the COVID-19 transition; 98% student satisfaction, 120% enrollment growth.

2021 **Education Programme Intern**, UNESCO Beijing Cluster Office

- Drafted policy reports on regional TVET initiatives with a focus on equity and access in Mongolia; coordinated stakeholder convenings with government and civil society partners.

Technical Skills

Methods	Causal inference (RD, DiD, IV, shift-share, matching); survey design and analysis; semi-structured interviewing; thematic and grounded theory coding; systematic review and framework synthesis
Software	Stata (advanced), R, Python; Tableau; Dedoose
Data	Longitudinal administrative data linkage and cleaning (state unit-record enrollment/transcript/UI wage systems; NSC, NLSY, IPEDS, QCEW)
Languages	Chinese (native), English (fluent), Japanese (advanced)

Service

Field	Discussant, APPAM (2026, scheduled); AEFP Conference Ambassador (2026); Award reviewer, CIES and CSCC (2026); Session organizer and chair, APPAM (2025); Conference proposal reviewer, SREE (2025), CSCC, CIES, AERA (2024)
Institution	Marsal Student Advisory Board (2026); Executive Board, Students of Color of Rackham (2023–24)
Member	AEFP · APPAM · ASHE · CSCC · SREE · CIES · AIR · ACTER